Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

May 2025

WOVEN AIR

A king's summertime gift for his queen



A 17thC king and commander of the Mughal Army in Rajasthan, one Rao Kishore Singh of Kota, married the princess of Udaipur, a city known for its many streams and lakes.

As Kota is blistering hot even by the desert region's standards, the king built an artificial lake by the palace for his sweltering princess. In addition, he gifted her a wardrobe made from a new, gossamer-fine, handwoven fabric, never seen before.



A 6½ metre Kota Doria saree weighs
a mere 250 gm

From where did he obtain it?

In his military incursions towards South India, he noticed women in Mysore wearing airy, handloom saris suited for the tropical Indian climate. He lost no time in bringing expert weavers from Mysore to Kota, settling them in the nearby village of Kaithoon. And so was born the innovative Kota Doria fabric (originally named Masuriya after the city of its origin). Part silk yarn and part cotton, Kota Doria came to be the royal fabric of Rajasthan, only worn by the nobility; woven for regal turbans on narrow looms and for floaty, graceful sarees on wider ones.



Gleaming pure silk, a modern tie-dye design in Kota Doria



A pink-purple shaded silk dupatta

The lightweight quality of Kota Doria fabric can be deceptive. Its sturdy khat weave lends itself to all-over embroidery and other embellishments.



Notice the intricate crochet edging along the lower right in this antique Kota saree



Tiny sequins gleam all over on this chikankari Kota, without affecting its delicate weave

In time, a pure cotton variety was also developed, as gossamer-light as the silk cotton, and with versatile uses. One no longer needed to be royalty to own exquisite Kota Doria sarees, stoles or odhnis.



The pale pastel print of olive, blues and rose enhance the delicacy of this fine, pure cotton saree

For the women artisans of Kaithoon, the day begins with dyeing and hanging out the skeins of yarn (supplied by agents from Bangalore and Surat). The desert heat ensures that skeins are fully dry by end of day. The women repeat the dyeing and drying process for two more days till the dye is fixed. The ropes of yarn are then made firm by dipping them in rice paste and, interestingly, onion juice. They are then dried one last time and made into bundles. No additional finishing is needed.



The rich dyes of bandhani and the gauzy Kota Doria are a combined tribute to Rajasthan

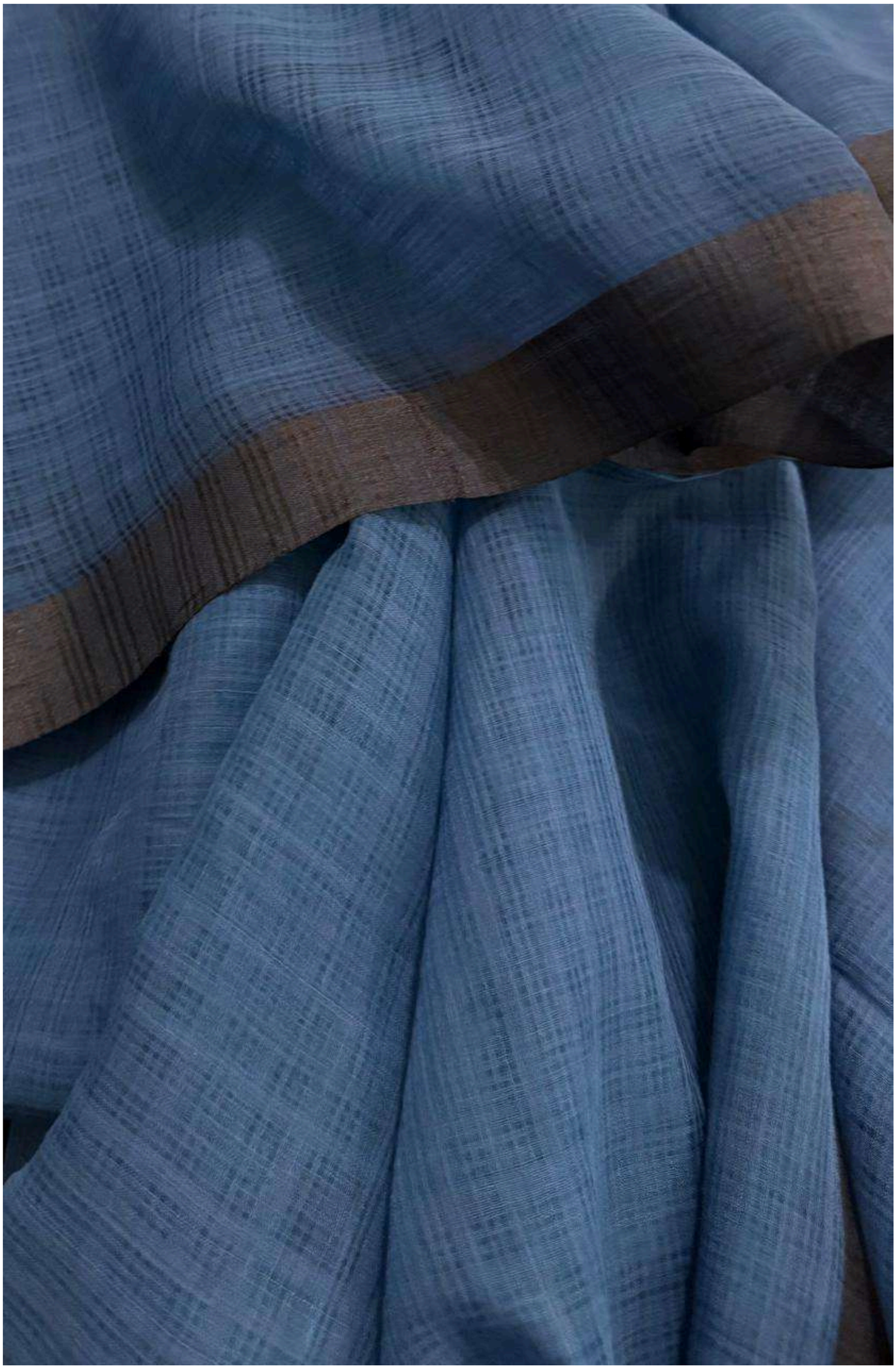
The yarns are now inserted into the looms. After setting the fine khat checks (like ‘graph paper’), characteristic of Kota Doria, the long, intricate task of weaving begins. Once the fabric comes off the loom, it is ready for block-printing, embroidery or any other embellishment.



Classic smart batik...



...and an intricate Sanganer print.
The amazingly strong Kota Doria fabric
favours almost any design.



A rare indigo with a restrained charcoal border

While more than 15 persons in a unit are engaged in the making of Kota Doria, it's the women of the artisan families who take charge of the intricate task of weaving. This helps them earn a livelihood and self-confidence. Girl children are encouraged to attend school but have the choice later to join the family business.



Clearly, Raja Rao Kishore Singh started a movement for empowering the women of Kota, in more ways than one.